

Plato and Aristotle — MCQ Questions

Philosophy Optional • Paper I • Western Philosophy

Attempt closed-book. Record option, reasoning and confidence in PRACTICE-LOG.md before opening MCQ-SOLUTIONS.md. Questions retain canonical numbering; no key or explanation is present here.

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MCQ 1. What the theory of Forms is posited to solve

Consider the following statements about Plato's motivation for positing Forms (*eidē*).

1. Many sensible things are called by the same predicate, so a single intelligible character must be common to them.
2. Strict knowledge (*epistēmē*) requires an object that does not change, which sensible particulars cannot supply.
3. The theory is introduced principally to explain the efficient production of motion in the sensible world.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 3 only
- B. 1 and 2 only
- C. 2 and 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

MCQ 2. The exact sense of the "separation" of the Forms

When Plato is said to hold that Forms are separate from sensible particulars, the claim is best understood as meaning that

- A. Forms occupy a second physical location, lying spatially remote from the world our senses reach
- B. Forms are shared concepts assembled in the minds of those who use a common predicate correctly
- C. Forms exist independently of their sensible instances and are non-spatial and non-temporal
- D. Forms are the microscopic constituents out of which sensible particulars are assembled

MCQ 3. Matching each argument for the Forms to its structure

Match each argument with its distinctive move.

1. One-over-many — 2. Argument from knowledge — 3. Argument from opposites — 4. Recollection (*anamnēsis*)

I. Sensible things are both F and not-F in different relations, whereas the F itself never is. II. We judge sensibles as falling short of a perfection we never met in sense, so the soul must have known it before. III. A common predicate applied to many requires one thing they all share. IV. Knowledge needs a stable object, and sensibles are in flux.

Which of the following is the correct matching?

- A. 1–III, 2–IV, 3–I, 4–II
- B. 1–IV, 2–III, 3–II, 4–I
- C. 1–III, 2–I, 3–IV, 4–II
- D. 1–II, 2–IV, 3–I, 4–III

MCQ 4. "Ideas are timeless and spaceless"

The property that most directly explains why Forms can be objects of knowledge rather than of opinion is that they

- A. are more numerous and far more finely differentiated than the sensible things that imitate them
- B. admit no generation or alteration and occupy no position, being self-identically what they are
- C. are perceived by an inner sense which operates on much the same principles as ordinary sight
- D. change far more slowly than sensible particulars and therefore approximate stability more closely

MCQ 5. What counts as substance for Plato

On Plato's view, true substance (*ousia*) is

- A. the concrete individual before us, since it alone is the ultimate subject of every predication
- B. the underlying matter, which persists unchanged through every change the individual undergoes
- C. the compound formed from an intelligible structure and a portion of the Receptacle
- D. the universal Form, with particulars possessing being only derivatively through participation

MCQ 6. The Divided Line

In the Divided Line of *Republic* VI 509d–511e, the ascending order of states of mind and their objects is

- A. *pistis* — images; *eikasia* — visible things; *noēsis* — mathematical objects; *dianoia* — Forms
- B. *eikasia* — visible things; *pistis* — images; *dianoia* — Forms; *noēsis* — mathematical objects
- C. *dianoia* — images; *noēsis* — visible things; *eikasia* — mathematical objects; *pistis* — Forms
- D. *eikasia* — images; *pistis* — visible things; *dianoia* — mathematical objects; *noēsis* — Forms

MCQ 7. What separates *dianoia* from *noēsi*

The decisive difference between thought (*dianoia*) and intellection (*noēsis*) in the Divided Line lies in

- A. the relative difficulty of the subject matter, geometry being distinctly easier than dialectic
- B. the direction of argument and the use of images, mathematics reasoning downward from hypotheses
- C. the number of premises each one employs, dialectic requiring more steps than geometrical demonstration
- D. the fact that only intellection is exercised by philosophers, since mathematics belongs to artisans

MCQ 8. What the Cave adds to the Line

Consider the following statements about the Allegory of the Cave, *Republic* VII 514a–517a.

1. The ascent is described as painful and compelled, and education is presented as turning an organ of vision the soul already possesses.
2. The philosopher must descend again into the cave, will see badly in the dark and may be met with ridicule or violence.
3. The allegory replaces the epistemological scheme of the Line with an independent political doctrine.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 only
- B. 2 and 3 only
- C. 1 and 2 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

MCQ 9. The Sun analogy

In the Sun analogy of *Republic* VI 507a–509c, the Form of the Good stands to the intelligible order as the sun stands to the visible order because the Good

- A. illuminates the Forms for the mind without contributing anything at all to what they are
- B. confers on the Forms both their knowability and their being, and lies itself beyond being
- C. is the efficient craftsman who fashions the Forms out of some pre-existing material stuff
- D. is simply the highest member of the class of Forms, differing from all the rest only in rank

MCQ 10. The participation dilemma

The dilemma about participation raised at *Parmenides* 131a–c presses the question whether

- A. the whole Form or only a part of it is present in each participant, neither answer being coherent
- B. Forms exist at all, given that nobody has ever perceived a single one of them by sight or touch

- C. participation is really a relation between two Forms rather than between a Form and a particular
- D. the Form of the Good participates in the lesser Forms in the way that particulars participate in Forms

MCQ 11. The presuppositions of the Third Man

The regress known as the Third Man requires which pair of assumptions?

- A. That Forms are causally inert, and that sensible particulars are altogether unreal things
- B. That knowledge is recollection, and that the soul pre-exists the body it later occupies
- C. That the Form of F is itself F, and that the explaining Form differs from what it explains
- D. That every predicate has its own Form, and that the sensible world is in a ceaseless flux

MCQ 12. Plato's wider causal resources

Which statement most accurately describes Plato's explanatory apparatus once the *Timaeus* is taken into account?

- A. Forms give formal explanation, the Good grounds being and intelligibility, and the Demiurge orders becoming after the Forms
- B. The Form of the Good and the Demiurge are two names for one creator who produces the Forms and the sensible world alike
- C. The Receptacle (*chōra*) is Plato's term for matter and functions exactly as Aristotle's *hylē* does in hylomorphic analysis
- D. Plato offers only one kind of cause, so Aristotle's charge that he cannot explain motion applies without any qualification

MCQ 13. Aristotle's critique of separated Forms

Which of the following states the "duplication" objection of *Metaphysics* I.9 correctly?

- A. Forms cannot be defined at all, because definition requires a genus and a differentia that Forms lack
- B. Forms are wholly unknowable, because knowledge proceeds only from the sense-perception of particulars
- C. Separated Forms double the entities requiring explanation, leaving two sets where there was one
- D. Forms are impossible, because nothing whatever can exist that is not located in space and in time

MCQ 14. Aristotle's repair of the theory of Forms

Aristotle's response to Plato is best described as

- A. rejecting form and universality altogether in favour of a strict materialism of atoms and void
- B. retaining Plato's separated Forms while adding efficient causation so as to make them effective
- C. accepting the Forms for mathematical objects while denying them for natural substances
- D. retaining intelligible form but making it immanent in the composite rather than separate

MCQ 15. Substance in the *Categories*

In the *Categories* (2a11 ff.), primary and secondary substance are related as follows.

- A. Primary substance is the species and secondary substance is the individual, since the species is more knowable
- B. Primary substance is the essence and secondary substance is the matter, since the essence explains the matter
- C. Primary substance is the concrete individual, and species and genus are secondary substances said of it
- D. Primary substance is the genus and secondary substance is the accident, since accidents inhere in genera

MCQ 16. The four candidates for substance in *Metaphysics* Z.3

Aristotle reviews substratum, essence, universal and genus as candidates for substance. His adjudication is that

- A. essence is accepted, the universal and the genus are rejected, and bare matter is neither a "this" nor separable
- B. the substratum taken as matter is accepted, because stripping away predicates leaves the one thing that truly underlies
- C. the genus is accepted, because it is the widest term under which the thing in question may be classified
- D. the universal is accepted, since Aristotle agrees with Plato that only what is common to many can explain

MCQ 17. The *Categories*/*Metaphysics* question

The safest way to handle the apparent conflict between the *Categories* and *Metaphysics* Z is to argue that

- A. the *Metaphysics* silently withdraws the *Categories*, so only the later of the two doctrines should be reported
- B. the two works are simply inconsistent and Aristotle himself never noticed the problem at all
- C. the two works answer different questions — which things are substances, and what the substance *of* a thing is
- D. "substance" is used equivocally in the two works, with no philosophical connection at all between the senses

MCQ 18. The ten categories

The ten categories of the *Categories* are best described as

- A. fundamental modes of predication and of being, only substance being a subject primarily
- B. ten physical components which jointly compose every material object that we encounter in nature
- C. ten successive stages through which every natural substance passes as it develops to maturity
- D. ten distinct kinds of cause, of which the final cause is much the most important of all

MCQ 19. Matter and form in hylomorphic analysis

Which statement about matter (*hylē*) and form (*morphē*) is correct?

- A. Matter and form are two independently existing objects that a craftsman joins mechanically together
- B. Matter is always the same featureless stuff, so bronze and wood differ only in the forms imposed on them
- C. Form is a separately existing paradigm that the matter of each substance imitates at a distance
- D. Matter is relative, since bronze is matter for the statue yet is itself formed from copper and tin

MCQ 20. Prime matter

The doctrine of prime matter (*prōtē hylē*) is best presented in an answer as

- A. a limiting posit of matter considered without determinate form and never existing independently
- B. an observable featureless stuff that chemists have since identified with the elementary particles
- C. a synonym for the Receptacle of Plato's *Timaeus*, which Aristotle adopted without any change
- D. the substantial form that is shared by all material things whatever their species may be

MCQ 21. The four causes

Which statement about the four causes (*aitiai*) is correct?

- A. They are four successive events, so the material cause acts first and the final cause acts last
- B. They are four competing hypotheses, of which the investigator must select the single true one
- C. They are four agents that act upon a thing from outside and may be observed quite separately
- D. They are four answers to "why?" about one thing, and in nature three of them typically coincide

MCQ 22. Change, privation and the two kinds of change

Consider the following statements about Aristotle's analysis of change.

1. Coming-to-be is analysed through an underlying subject, an acquired form and the prior privation (*sterēsis*) of that form.
2. In accidental change the substantial form persists while a quantity, quality, place or other accident alters.
3. In substantial generation the prior substantial form persists as the identity of the new substance.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 2 only
- B. 2 and 3 only
- C. 1 and 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

MCQ 23. Potentiality and actuality

Aristotle's definition of change at *Physics* III.1 (201a10) is best rendered as

- A. the actuality of the potential as potential, a passage from potential to actual being
- B. the replacement of one actual thing by another actual thing that is numerically different
- C. the movement of matter through space under the action of some external moving agency
- D. the appearance of a wholly new being out of absolute non-being at each successive moment

MCQ 24. The priority of actuality

Aristotle argues that actuality (*energeia*) is prior to potentiality (*dynamis*) in which respects?

- A. In spatial position, in numerical count and in bare perceptibility to the senses

- B. In causal power, in metaphysical dignity and in popularity among his later successors
- C. In explanatory efficiency, in theoretical economy and in the overall simplicity of statement
- D. In definition, in time at the species level, and in substance as the end of the process

MCQ 25. Remedial drill — what Plato says about the physical world

A candidate writes that Plato "denies the reality of the physical world". The correct correction is that Plato

- A. holds the sensible world to be a systematic illusion projected by ignorance, much as Advaita treats *māyā*
- B. grants sensible particulars a real but derivative being as copies of Forms, hence objects of opinion
- C. treats the physical world as fully real and equal in status to the Forms, differing only in accessibility
- D. leaves the ontological status of the physical world entirely undetermined throughout the dialogues

MCQ 26. Remedial drill — what Aristotle denies about universals

Which correction of the claim that "Aristotle denies universals" is accurate?

- A. He denies universals in logic but retains them in physics, where species-terms are indispensable
- B. He accepts universals as separately existing entities but denies that they can ever be known
- C. He accepts universals only as names, holding that nothing in reality corresponds to a general term
- D. He retains species and genus as secondary substances, denying only their separate existence

MCQ 27. Remedial drill — what potentiality is not

The claim that "potentiality is indefinable", tested in 2021, is best explained by saying that potentiality

- A. is a statistical likelihood that a given outcome will occur, measurable in principle by frequency
- B. cannot be defined independently of actuality, since "potentially a table" presupposes an actual table
- C. is undefinable because Aristotle nowhere discusses it, leaving only later commentators to supply an account
- D. is a hidden quality inside matter that can be detected once the matter is sufficiently divided

MCQ 28. Remedial drill — how the Unmoved Mover moves

The Unmoved Mover of *Metaphysics* XII (Λ).7 moves the cosmos

- A. by efficient causation, imparting motion to the outermost sphere by direct physical contact with it
- B. by creating the world out of nothing at a first moment of time, before which nothing existed
- C. as a final cause, being the object of desire and thought — it "moves as the beloved moves the lover"
- D. by continuously sustaining matter in existence, acting as a conserving cause at every instant

MCQ 29. Remedial drill — the four causes as explanation, not narrative

A script states: "First the material cause supplies wood, then the efficient cause acts, then the formal cause appears, and finally the final cause is reached." The error is that

- A. the order given is right but the labels have been interchanged between the formal and final causes
- B. the four are aspects of one explanation and may be simultaneous rather than successive events
- C. there are five causes on Aristotle's mature view, and the list omits the instrumental cause
- D. only the efficient cause is a genuine cause, the other three being metaphors for it

MCQ 30. Remedial drill — formal cause and Platonic Form

The relation between Aristotle's formal cause and Plato's Form is that

- A. they are the same entity described in two vocabularies, so the dispute between the two philosophers is merely verbal
- B. both are called *eidos*, but Aristotle's is immanent in *this* composite and Plato's is separate
- C. the formal cause is a mental concept, whereas the Platonic Form is an object outside the mind
- D. Aristotle abandoned the word *eidos* precisely in order to mark his break with his teacher

MCQ 31. Remedial drill — the standing of the "mathematicals"

The doctrine that Plato posited mathematical objects as intermediates (*ta metaxu*) between Forms and sensibles should be reported as

- A. a doctrine stated explicitly in the *Republic* alongside the account of the Divided Line
- B. a modern scholarly conjecture with no ancient textual or doxographical support whatever
- C. Aristotle's testimony at *Metaphysics* I.6 (987b14), not a doctrine stated in the dialogues
- D. a Neoplatonic addition of the third century which later editors inserted into the Platonic text

MCQ 32. Remedial drill — citation and verdict discipline

Which answer-writing practice is defensible in this topic?

- A. Quoting long passages of Jowett's translation from memory to establish the exact wording of a Platonic argument
- B. Citing "Plato, *Republic*, Chapter 7, page 214" so that the examiner can locate the passage in a particular printed edition
- C. Ending a comparison with a balanced description of both thinkers and no ruling, since UPSC penalises taking sides
- D. Citing Plato by Stephanus pagination and Aristotle by Bekker numbers, and closing with a graded verdict

MCQ 33. The Receptacle as a third kind

Consider the following statements about the Receptacle (*chōra*) in Plato's *Timaeus*.

1. It is introduced as a difficult third kind, distinct from the intelligible Forms and the sensible becoming that appears in it.
2. It is a determinate material body manufactured by the Demiurge before the Demiurge copies the Forms.
3. Its receiving role does not by itself make it straightforwardly identical with Aristotle's matter.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 only
- B. 2 and 3 only
- C. 1 and 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

MCQ 34. Prime matter and substantial generation

A candidate explains radical generation by saying that prime matter is "the smallest separable stuff left after every observable property is removed". Which correction is most accurate?

- A. Prime matter is a non-separable limit concept of pure potentiality required for substantial generation, not a bare body available for inspection.
- B. Prime matter is the last determinate element surviving every substantial change, and its continued identity numerically anchors the newly generated substance.
- C. Prime matter is Aristotle's revised name for the Platonic Receptacle, now treated as the common spatial container of all sensible forms.

D. Prime matter is dispensable because genuine generation is only accidental alteration in which the underlying substance and its substantial form both remain.

MCQ 35. What makes Aristotelian teleology internal

An acorn develops into an oak under ordinary natural conditions. Consider the following interpretations.

1. The mature form is the terminus toward which the organism's own powers are directed.
2. The explanation need not attribute conscious foresight either to the acorn or to an external designer.
3. The account differs both from imitation of a separated Platonic paradigm and from an explanation restricted to material impact and efficient sequence.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 2 only
- B. 2 and 3 only
- C. 1 and 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

MCQ 36. Applying the two substance questions

A horse is the ultimate subject of predicates such as "brown" and "swift", yet an enquirer asks why these bones and tissues constitute a horse rather than a heap. Which reading best applies Aristotle without conflating his texts?

- A. The *Categories* and *Metaphysics Z* give rival lists of primary substances, so one of the two accounts must be discarded.
- B. The *Categories* identifies the individual horse by subjecthood, while Z seeks the form or essence that explains the substancehood of that individual.
- C. The individual is primary in both works because form and essence are merely accidental predicates said of an independently complete matter.
- D. Form is primary in both works because the concrete horse is only a deficient copy of a separately existing equine universal.

MCQ 37. Pure actuality, immobility and final causation

Consider the following statements about Aristotle's Unmoved Mover.

1. Any unrealised potentiality would make it capable of being otherwise and therefore dependent on change for its fulfilment.

2. Its motion of the cosmos is final rather than efficient: it is desired and thought, not a body that transmits motion by contact.
3. Its immobility means that it can have no explanatory relation to motion and is retained only as an honorific name for the cosmos.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 2 and 3 only
- B. 1 and 3 only
- C. 1 and 2 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

MCQ 38. One problem, two rejected answers, one repair

Which option correctly matches Aristotle's objections to the Atomists and Plato with his positive account of sensible substance?

- A. Atomism and Platonism fail for the same reason, namely denial of particulars; Aristotle repairs both by making universals separate substances.
- B. Atomism wrongly multiplies immaterial universals; Plato wrongly reduces reality to collisions; Aristotle retains efficient causation alone.
- C. Atomism fails because atoms change their essences; Plato fails because Forms are material; Aristotle replaces both with prime matter alone.
- D. Atomism lacks internal form and final explanation; separated Forms lack immanent causal purchase; hylomorphic substances are explained through all four causes.

MCQ 39. Immanent form and the problem of universals

Why is it more accurate to say that Aristotle relocates, rather than simply eliminates, the problem of universals?

- A. He makes form immanent and causally explanatory, yet must still reconcile science's universal object with Z.13's denial that any universal is substance.
- B. He makes every species a separately existing substance, but locates that substance inside a physical place occupied by its instances.
- C. He denies that definition concerns form, so knowledge must shift from universal essences to the accidental histories of individuals.
- D. He treats universals as names only, although scientific definitions continue to use general terms as convenient summaries of individual histories.

MCQ 40. Blocking the regress without paying the causal debt

A Platonist denies that the Form of Large is large in the same way as a large mountain and therefore blocks the self-predication premise of the Third Man. What follows?

- A. The theory is fully vindicated because every major Aristotelian objection to separated Forms, including causal impotence, depends on self-predication.
- B. The specific regress is weakened, but participation still needs a non-metaphorical account of how separated Forms explain particulars and change.
- C. The participation dilemma is solved because a non-self-predicating Form can be divided among its instances without itself having parts.
- D. The causal problem disappears because denying self-predication converts each Form into the efficient cause of its sensible copies.